

you aren't ready to actually make a meaningful offer, you don't have your line in the water—and you won't even get a bite.

In most cases, a deal that is truly competitively priced will go under contract within a few days of listing. While you don't need to drop everything you're doing at two o'clock sharp to see the house at two thirty, you will have to cancel your evening plans to make an offer within twenty-four hours of that listing coming online.

We know it sounds like you're making a very high-pressure decision on the spot, but that's not the case. You've already tied your flies and casted your line, remember? You're making a calm, collected, confident decision about what house you want far in advance. Now all you have to do is simply react when what you planned for all along actually hits the market.

This is exactly how you give yourself the best possible odds of getting a good deal. Put in the work up front, wait patiently, and when you see what you've been looking for, act aggressively. You will feel your heart drop to your toes when you make that first, fast offer, but the rewards will come soon enough—when you move into your reasonably priced, comfortable home and can paint all the walls Don't Cry Over Spilled Milk white.

CHAPTER SUMMARY

- Buying a home isn't the easiest thing in the world. If you want the best chance of purchasing a home at a great price, you need to prepare in advance.
- First, you'll need to get your finances in order. Your credit score should be 700-plus, your source of income should be stable, your debt-to-income ratio should be less than 45 percent, and you should have a big chunk of cheddar in the bank to cover the down payment and closing costs and have some money left over.
- Don't rush it. If you're under the pressure of a big life event, recognize that you're probably creating an artificial timeline for yourself. If you're on a deadline to move out of a rental, set up a month-to-month lease instead of racing against the clock.
- Know what you want from the house itself and know what a good, reasonable deal is. Pick out specific neighborhoods and home types